

DUALITY

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Difficulty \ Outcome	Very Bad	Bad	Mixed	Good	Very Good
Very Easy	≤ -1	0 – 2	3 – 5	6 – 8	≥ 9
Easy	≤ 2	3 – 5	6 – 8	9 – 11	≥ 12
Medium	≤ 5	6 – 8	9 – 11	12 – 14	≥ 15
Hard	≤ 8	9 – 11	12 – 14	15 – 17	≥ 18
Very Hard	≤ 11	12 – 14	15 – 17	18 – 20	≥ 21

Table 1: Outcome Table for Unopposed Rolls

Difference	≤ -6	-5 – -3	-2 – 2	3 – 5	≥ 6
Outcome	Very Bad	Bad	Mixed	Good	Very Good

Table 2: Outcome Table for Opposed Rolls

1 Rolls

When a Player Character (PC) attempts to do something that is not certain, they must roll for it. There are two types of roll: opposed rolls for when another character is resisting the effort and unopposed rolls for when success is not guaranteed but nobody is actively resisting the effort. The result of a roll is measured by an **Outcome**: *Very Bad*, *Bad*, *Mixed*, *Good*, or *Very Good*.

When the *Outcome* of a roll is *Mixed* or better (*Mixed*, *Good*, or *Very Good*), the PC achieves what they rolled for; on a *Very Good* outcome they either achieve something extra or gain an *Advantage*. When the *Outcome* is *Mixed* or worse (*Mixed*, *Bad*, or *Very Bad*), there is either a negative repercussion, and a particularly bad repercussion on a *Very Bad* result, or the GM gains an *Advantage*, or two on a *Very Bad* result.

1.1 Unopposed Rolls

For an unopposed roll, the GM will select the appropriate *Attribute* for the task and whether the character has an appropriate *Specialization* and determine whether an *Experience* suggested by the player would apply. Then, accounting for the nature of the task, and the character's *Specialization*, if any, the GM will determine the **Difficulty** for the task, which is *Very Easy*, *Easy*, *Medium*, *Hard*, or *Very Hard*. The player then rolls 2d8 and adds their *Attribute* bonus, relevant *Specialization* bonus if any, and relevant *Experience* bonus if any. This total is then compared to Table 1 to determine the *Outcome*.

1.2 Opposed Rolls

For an opposed roll, both the Player and GM roll and add their appropriate *Attribute*, *Specialization*, and *Experience* bonuses as appropriate. Then, the Player's result is computed as their roll minus the GM's roll and this is compared to Table 2. Similarly, the GM's result is computed as their roll minus the Player's and this is compared to Table 2.

1.3 Group Rolls

Groups rolls, for circumstances where multiple characters are working together on something or all doing something where failures can impact each other, have slightly different rules. There are two types of Group rolls, whose rules are detailed below.

1.3.1 Collective Rolls

A Collective Roll is used when characters are working together on a large task that could not be reasonably be completed by just one. For example, a Collective Roll might be used when a group of PCs is researching in a large library looking for information pertaining to the location of an ancient ruin. In a Collective Roll, the GM may also allow multiple rounds of rolls to be collected together for tasks that might take more time and effort than just the single roll.

For a Collective Roll, the GM sets a *Difficulty* and a **Magnitude** (a whole number). The characters then each roll as normal, but instead of converting their roll to an outcome, they instead total their rolls together. This total

is then divided by the *Magnitude* set by the GM (always rounding towards zero) and then this result is compared to Table 1 to determine the group's outcome of the roll.

In our example of searching a library, the GM may determine that this task is relatively easy and risk free and set a *Difficulty* of *Easy* but because of the massive size of the library determine that the *Magnitude* is 10. Then, if the party rolls a total of 58, we divide this by the *Magnitude* to get a 5, which is a *Bad* outcome.

When a GM allows multiple rounds of rolls, the party totals their rolls from each round together and then divides by the *Magnitude* to determine the *Outcome* for each round. While a *Bad* or *Very Bad* result on a round of rolls is not a failure of the entire effort, the GM may still impose negative outcomes or gain *Advantage* for each round until the group reaches a *Mixed* or better result.

If the GM for the party searching the library allows the party another round, the GM may collect an *Advantage* for the failure on the first round (or impose some negative outcome). The party then rolls a total of 43 on the next round, for a total of 101 now, which is a 10 after division by the *Magnitude* and is therefore a *Mixed* result now. The party therefore has now found the information they are looking for, but the GM may take another *Advantage* or impose a negative outcome.

1.3.2 Cooperative Rolls

A Cooperative Roll is used when characters are each performing similar actions with similar goals but failures by some characters may impact the entire group. For example, a Cooperative Roll might be used when a group of PCs is sneaking into the collections of a museum seeking an artifact not on display.

For a Cooperative Roll, the GM sets a *Difficulty* for each character which each character rolls against. This *Difficulty* and the *Attribute* used for the roll is often the same for all characters involved but not necessarily. Then, the total successes and failures are totaled, where a *Very Bad* counts as -2 , *Bad* as -1 , *Mixed* as 0 , *Good* as $+1$, and *Very Good* as $+2$. This total then is converted into an *Outcome* in the same manner, so a result of -2 or less is *Very Bad*, -1 is *Bad*, 0 is *Mixed*, 1 is *Good*, and 2 or higher is *Very Good*. The GM may also allow that if the result is greater than $+2$ or less than -2 that the players or GM, respectively, gain additional *Advantage*, for example that $+3$ is a *Very Good* result and generates an additional *Advantage*.

For our party attempting to sneak into the museum collections, the GM may set a *Difficulty* of *Hard* and have each PC roll *Dexterity* for sneaking. If the party rolls two *Bad*, one *Mixed*, and one *Very Good* result, the outcome of the roll is *Mixed*. If, instead, they had rolled two *Bad*, one *Good*, and one *Very Good* the outcome would be *Good*.

1.4 Helping Out

A character can **Help** another creature on a roll with approval from that creature and the GM. Based on how they are helping out, the GM will pick the parameters of the roll for the helper as usual; this will generally be against a *Medium* difficulty though the GM may adjust this for particularly difficult tasks or when the assistance is difficult to render. On a *Mixed* or better result the creature being helped gains an *Advantage*.

1.5 Increased and Decreased Rolls

In some circumstances a character's roll may be **Increased** or **Decreased**. *Increases* and *Decreases* can stack and cancel each other out, so one *Increase* and one *Decrease* cancel out, while two *Increases* and one *Decrease* cancel out to one *Increase*.

On a roll which is *Increased* n times, roll $n + 2$ d8s and total only the highest two. On a roll which is *Decreased* n times, roll $n + 2$ d8s and total only the lowest two.

1.6 Specialized Rolls

Sometimes given the circumstances of a roll the GM will impose special rules.

The GM may declare a roll to be **Dangerous** in which case a *Bad* outcome is treated as a *Very Bad* outcome.

The GM may declare a roll to be **Tiered** when a partial success is possible and likely, for example when a character is trying to ascertain many things at once; the GM sets a *base difficulty* as usual and can then decide that certain levels of success are only attainable if the roll meets or exceeds a certain outcome or target number.

2 Advantages

Advantage are meta-currency which represent power, preparation, luck, and other circumstances that may benefit the players or the GM. Each Player can collect *Advantage*, as can the GM. *Advantage* can be spent in a number of ways, detailed below and there may be other options that a GM allows or that are available based on particular creatures' abilities. In general, players can spend their *Advantage* to help other characters but their use should always make narrative sense; players should explain how they are narratively assisting and the GM may decide that a use of *Advantage* is not possible given the circumstances.

1. *Increasing a roll*: An *Advantage* can be spent to *Increase* a roll.
2. *Decreasing a roll*: An *Advantage* can be spent to *Decrease* a roll.
3. *Increase damage*: An *Advantage* can be spent to increase the number of damage dice rolled by a creature by one. If there are multiple different dice (like a d6 and a d8) that would be rolled, the additional die is the same as the larger die (so the d8 instead of the d6).
4. *Decrease damage*: An *Advantage* can be spent to reduce the number of damage dice rolled by a creature by one. If there are multiple different dice (like a d6 and a d8) that would be rolled, the die that is removed is the larger die (so the d8 instead of the d6).

3 Character Statistics

Characters are defined by their *Attributes*, *Specializations*, *Experiences*, *Abilities*, and *Combat Styles*. *Attributes* define the character's broad statistics as well as their movement, wealth, and ability to take damage. *Specializations* define specific skills that the character possesses and the nature of those skills. *Experiences* reflect the character's past and offer bonuses to rolls in certain circumstances. *Abilities* provide unique mechanics for a character. *Combat Styles* define a character's fighting style, both offensive and defensive.

3.1 Attributes

Character **Attributes** represent the character's basic abilities. Each character has four kinds of attributes that describe: their base statistics, their health, their movement abilities, and their wealth.

3.1.1 Basic Statistics

A character's basic statistics are defined by six *Attributes*: **Strength**, **Finesse**, **Willpower**, **Instinct**, **Presence**, and **Knowledge**. These *Attributes* each have a numeric value between -1 and $+2$ (for starting characters) and may increase to $+3$ when a character levels up.

These *Attribute* values provide bonuses that are applied to rolls. The GM should pick the *Attribute* that makes most sense for the roll:

- **Strength**: A character's physical strength; their ability to lift, carry, climb.
- **Finesse**: A character's manual dexterity and control and their ability to move carefully and quietly.
- **Willpower**: A character's will to live; their ability to push off death and rely on pure luck.
- **Instinct**: A character's senses and intuition; their ability to perceive, sense motive, evaluate.
- **Presence**: A character's person skills; their ability to convince or deceive, to put on a performance.
- **Knowledge**: A character's knowledge and experience; their ability to recall and analyze.

3.1.2 Health

There are three health related *Attributes*: **Life**, **Recovery**, and **Block**. A creature's *Life* defines how much damage it can it until it falls unconscious or dies. Its *Recovery* defines how much *Life* a creature regains when it heals, rests, and recuperates. *Block* defines how much damage a creature can just absorb without any impact, as described later *Block* is subtracted from damage dealt to a creature before subtracting the damage from its *Life*.

A character's *Maximum Life* has a numeric score between 1 and 40, its *Recovery* a numeric score between 1 and 20, and its *Block* a numeric score between 0 and 2. Other creatures may have values outside of these ranges.

Wealth Value	Example Purchases
None	nothing
Limited	basic food and lodging daily
Modest	basic (though sturdy) supplies like rope, arrows, and tents
Comfortable	rare supplies like climbing equipment, a day of unskilled labor, a beast of burden
Luxurious	a sailboat, a comfortable wagon, a day of skilled labor
Aristocratic	a mercenary, an abandoned warehouse or small property

Table 3: Wealth

3.1.3 Movement

Each creature has a **Speed** which determines how fast it moves and has *Attributes* which determine by what means. A creature's *Speed* is one of *Slow*, *Normal*, and *Fast* which abstractly define how quickly it can move. Note that these speeds should be interpreted in the full context of a creature, a *Slow* dragon may still fly faster than a *Fast* snail or even mouse can move, though alternatively a *Fast* dragon may still walk slower than a *Normal* mouse can.

By default a creature's speed is its *Walking* speed, but a creature may also be able *Climb*, *Burrow*, *Swim*, and *Fly*; each of these is its own *Attribute* a character can possess which indicates whether it can move in that manner.

3.1.4 Wealth

The **Wealth** *Attribute* describes how much money a creature has and can easily spend. Creatures with a high *Wealth* are able to make larger purchases, without expending other meta-resources, than a creature with low *Wealth*. *Wealth* has one of the values in Table 3 which also describes the sorts of things that can be bought with that level.

3.2 Specializations

Specializations represent talents and abilities a creature has. There are a total of sixty possible specializations, each described by the combination of a verb and noun and each character may possess a bonus associated with the specializations which can be used on relevant rolls and a *tag* describing special mechanics for the character when they use that specialization. The verbs and nouns that define *Specializations* are:

- **Verbs:** *Control, Create, Destroy, Perceive, Know, Transform*
- **Nouns:** *Air, Earth, Fire, Water, Animals, Plants, Body, Illusion, Mind, Arcana*

The bonus for each *Specialization* can be 0, +1, or +2 (for starting characters) and may increase up to +4 when a character levels up.

Each *Specialization* has an associated tag that specifies the limits of the character's ability with that *Specialization*. These tags are:

- **Human:** the character can only perform within normal human ability.
- **Superhuman:** the character can perform within normal human ability easily (-1 *Difficulty*¹) and can perform with superhuman ability (though within the laws of nature).
- **Simple & Weak:** the character can perform simple acts of magic easily (-1 *Difficulty*) and can perform trivial acts of magic without a roll; the extent of the ability must be narrowly defined between the Player and GM.
- **Complex & Powerful:** the character can perform complex acts of magic but any act of magic is difficult ($+1$ *Difficulty*); the extent of the ability is widely defined and should be pushed to the limits. Failures on rolls to perform magic often result in magic gone awry.

In general, a tag cannot be changed after character creation unless the *Specialization* only had a bonus of +0 and the *Human* tag in which case the new tag represents learning a new ability. The GM may allow changing tags in other situations as makes sense with the story.

¹On an opposed roll, if a creature has a -1 *Difficulty* they add a +3 bonus to their roll and if they have a $+1$ *Difficulty* they add a -3 penalty to their roll.

Note that with magic setting the base difficulty of the roll depends on how magic is being used. If the use of magic is ancillary to the task, for example a character is conjuring fire in their hand in an attempt to intimidate a Lord, then the base difficulty is the difficulty of the task they are attempting to accomplish, in our example intimidating the Lord. If, instead, the use of magic is essential to the task, especially if the task could not be accomplished without magic, then the base difficulty is generally *Medium*. In both cases, the GM may adjust the difficulty as appropriate to the situation; for example they may increase the difficulty if there is limited time or if the Lord is familiar with magic and unlikely to be spooked, or may decrease the difficulty if, for instance, the Lord has never seen magic before.

3.2.1 Big Magic

While the *Complex & Powerful* tag provides a character access to powerful and broad magic, there should still be things beyond their capacity. When starting a campaign, a group should discuss what kinds of magics are beyond the capability of this tag; some examples that may be beyond the tag are magics that are permanent or have a long lasting impact and magic that has a large area of impact or impacts a large number of targets. Magic beyond what be achieved using the *Complex & Powerful* tag is the realm of **Big Magic**.

To perform Big Magic requires more time, ability, and possibly resources than normal magic. First, to undertake Big Magic, at least one character involved must have a relevant specialization with the *Complex & Powerful* tag because the ability to perform Big Magic still relies on some ability to perform magic. Next, the GM may determine that a particular act of Big Magic requires some resources: these can be *common* resources in which case the GM picks a wealth value required to acquire them or *rare* resources which would require some kind of quest to acquire. For *rare* resources, instead of going on a new quest the GM may allow the use of some number of XP to cover the resource cost, but this would only be done when the Big Magic being worked on will have a permanent impact on the party or important ally. Once any necessary resources have been acquired, performing Big Magic requires a Collective Roll, often with a high magnitude. Generally the Difficulty of the roll is Hard (because it relies on the *Complex & Powerful* tag) but the GM may chose to increase or decrease this Difficulty. Each roll as part of the Collective roll represents preparations and efforts to perform the magic and it can be assisted by any number of creatures, only one of whom needs to be rolling for a relevant *Specialization*. Generally each roll represents about two hours of work, though the GM may increase or decrease this time as appropriate, for example a group of experienced practitioners may be faster while novice ones may be slower.

On rolls for Big Magic, bringing additional materials and resources, especially ones connected to the magic being performed, can be used, at the GMs discretion, to gain an *Advantage* for the roll.

3.3 Experiences

Experiences provide additional depth to a character by detailing parts of their past that may provide useful experience in circumstances they encounter in adventuring. Each *Experience* has a short, couple word, description and a bonus attached to; when a character is attempting something related to one of their *Experiences* they can add the *Experience's* bonus to their roll. Good experiences will be broad enough that there are a number of possible circumstances they could apply but they should not be able to apply in all circumstances. Work with your GM and group to determine the appropriate breadth of *Experiences* for your game and to decide when an *Experience* applies. The bonus associated with an *Experience* is +1 or +2 for newly created characters and can be increased to +3 when a character levels up.

3.4 Abilities

Abilities provide additional unique mechanics for characters, generally to do with gaining or using *Advantage*. While not solely for non-magical characters, these *Ability* are designed to assist non-magical builds by offering additional options for play and ways to gain *Advantage*. Below is a list of such abilities, along with their XP costs; players and GMs should feel free to build other *Abilities* to match their desires. Several of these abilities have a *level n* which, for example, impacts the number of *Advantage* that a character gains; to take the ability you at first gain it at level 1 and can then spend the specified cost to increase it to level 2 and so on. When acquiring an ability whose cost depends on *n*, you must spend XP based on the level (*n*) you are upgrading to, so **Take the Advantage** costs 2 XP for level 1, another 3 XP for level 2, and so on.

- **Take the Advantage** (*n* + 1 XP): At the beginning of each session, gain *n* *Advantage*.

- **Good Under Pressure** (n XP): Once per session, ask the GM how many *Advantage* they have; if they have more than all Player Characters combined, gain n *Advantage*.
- **Tank** (n XP): When hit by attack, you can spend *Advantage* to decrease the damage you take by n per *Advantage*.
- **Natural Healer** (n XP): Each session, your first n attempts to triage creatures (as described in Section 4.3.1) do not require spending an *Advantage*.
- **Powerful Healer** (n XP): Each *Advantage* you spend to do additional healing when you triage a creature heals an additional n *Life*.
- **Draw Blood** (n XP): When you hit a target with an attack, you can spend two *Advantage* to inflict a *bleed* on the target. The target takes n damage immediately and at the beginning of each of their turns until they or an ally use an action or spend an *Advantage*, on their turn, to end the condition.

3.5 Combat Styles

Combat Styles define the character's abilities in combat, including their bonuses to attack and defend, their range for attacks, their damage, and other special abilities. Combat Styles are divided into *Offensive* and *Defensive* styles. Each character gets one Offensive and one Defensive style for free and then any additional style costs 3 XP. Each Combat Style, when chosen, is associated with a particular Basic Statistic which forms the base of the bonus for the style; when an additional Combat Style is chosen using the same statistic as another Combat Style the character already has, an additional 3 XP must be paid per such Combat Style (i.e., if a character has two Combat Styles that use Finesse then 6 XP must be paid to add a third Combat Style using Finesse). For Combat Styles that provide a bonus to attack or defend, this bonus can be increased for the same XP costs as a *Specialization* and is subject to the same maximum cap (as described below). Some Combat Styles have other upgrade options that are described with them. The Combat Style options are detailed below:

3.5.1 Offensive Combat Styles

Melee Choose a Basic Statistic as the base attack bonus; the character gains a +1 bonus to attacks with this style on top of the Basic Statistic's bonus. The range of attacks with this style is *in hand-to-hand combat*. Attacks with this style deal 1d8 damage plus the bonus granted by this style (not including the Basic Statistic). When you gain this Style, describe a new Experience (ideally related in some way to the character's combat abilities this style represents, for example related to knowledge of weapons, combat tactics, etc.); this Experience has a bonus equal to the attack bonus (not including the Basic Statistic) granted by this style.

Upgrades:

- The damage die can be changed to a d10 for 5 XP.
- The range can be changed to *just outside the reach of a similarly sized creature* for 2 XP.

Ranged Choose a Basic Statistic as the base attack bonus; the character gains a +1 bonus to attacks with this style on top of the Basic Statistic's bonus. The range of attacks with this style is *within a reasonable distance*. Attacks with this style deal 1d6 damage plus the bonus granted by this style (not including the Basic Statistic). When you gain this Style, describe a new Experience (ideally related in some way to the character's combat abilities this style represents, for example related to knowledge of weapons, combat tactics, etc.); this Experience has a bonus equal to the attack bonus (not including the Basic Statistic) granted by this style.

Upgrades:

- The damage die be changed to a d8 for 5 XP.
- The range can be changed to *from an unreasonable distance* for 2 XP.

Simple & Weak Choose a Basic Statistic as the base attack bonus; choose a *Specialization* with the Simple & Weak tag, the bonus to attacks using this style is the bonus to the Basic Statistic plus the bonus to this Specialization. Because this Style utilizes a Simple & Weak specialization, all attack rolls using this Style are at -1 Difficulty. The range of attacks with this style is *nearby*, meaning that the attacker can be targeted by both ranged and melee attacks from their target. Attacks with this style deal 1d4 damage plus the Specialization's bonus.

Upgrades:

- The damage die be changed to a d6 for 5 XP.
- The range can be changed to either *in hand-to-hand combat* or *within a reasonable distance* for 2 XP.

Complex & Powerful Choose a Basic Statistic as the base attack bonus; choose a *Specialization* with the Complex & Powerful tag, the bonus to attacks using this style is the bonus to the Basic Statistic plus the bonus to this Specialization. Because this Style utilizes a Complex & Powerful specialization, all attack rolls using this Style are at +1 Difficulty. The range of attacks with this style is *from an unreasonable distance*, but for attacks from a long range a -1 penalty should be applied to the roll. Attacks with this style deal 1d10 damage plus the Specialization's bonus.

Upgrades:

- The damage die be changed to a d12 for 5 XP.
- The penalty for attacks at long range can be eliminated for 2 XP.

3.5.2 Defensive Combat Styles

Evasive Choose a Basic Statistic as the base bonus to defend; the character gains a +1 bonus to defend with this style on top of the Basic Statistic's bonus.

Armored Choose a Basic Statistic as the base bonus to defend. When attacked, if the character does not use a Defend Action, they can still roll to defend but with a -3 penalty to the roll.

Shielded Choose a Basic Statistic as the base bonus to defend. The character also gains a +1 bonus to Block when using this style.

Upgrades:

- The bonus to block can be increased (up to a maximum of +2 at character creation or +5 thereafter) for XP equal to $3 \times$ the new bonus.

Riposte Choose a Basic Statistic as the base bonus to defend. When using this style, if the character is within range of the attacker, they can deal 1 damage to the attacker, regardless of the result of the roll.

Upgrades:

- The damage can be increased (to a maximum of 2 at character creation or 4 thereafter) for XP equal to the new amount of damage.

3.6 Character Creation and Leveling-Up

When creating a new character for a campaign, the GM should specify the number of *Experience Points* (XP) that the players have to start with to build their characters. A starting character (before spending any XP) has a +0 bonus for each of their basic statistics, a *Life* of 20, a *Recovery* of 10, a *Block* of 0, a *Speed* of *Normal* (and only the ability to walk), and a bonus of +0 and the *human* tag for all *Specializations*. A starting character also has one Offensive and one Defensive Combat Styles (for these to have the same Basic Statistic still costs 3 XP). A starting character also has one *Item* whose construction does not cost XP beyond the cost of the *Item* itself (see Section 5 for details). A starting character also has a *Wealth* of *Limited*. These statistics can be increased by spending XP, and in some cases decreased to gain XP, as follows:

- To increase a basic statistic (to a maximum of +2) by 1 costs $3 \times$ the score after the bonus; so increasing from +0 to +1 costs 3 XP, and from +1 to +2 costs 6. A basic statistic can also be decreased to -1 to gain 3 XP.
- To increase the character's Total *Life* costs 1 XP for each point up to 30 Total *Life* and then costs 2 XP for each point up to the maximum of 40. The Total *Life* can also be decreased to gain XP, gaining 1 XP per point down to 10 and then 2 XP per point down to a minimum of 1.
- To increase the character's *Recovery* costs 2 XP for each point up to 15 and then 4 XP for each point up to the maximum of 20. *Recovery* can also be reduced to gain XP, gaining 2 XP for each point down to 5 and 4 XP for each point down to the minimum of 1.

- Increasing the character's *Block* (up to a maximum of 2) costs $3\times$ the new block; so a block of 1 costs 3 XP and increasing that to 2 costs 6 XP.
- A character's *Speed* can be increased to *Fast* for 1 XP or can be reduced to *Slow* to gain 1 XP.
- A character can add a Climb or Swim speed at *Slow* for 6 XP, with it costing 1 XP to increase to *Normal* and another 1 XP to increase to *Fast*, a Burrow speed at *Slow* for 10 XP (with increasing speed costing the same), or a Fly speed for 16 XP (with increases costing the same).
- To increase a *Specialization* (up to a maximum of +2) bonus by +1 costs the score after the bonus; so increasing from +0 to +1 costs 1 XP and from +1 to +2 costs 2.
- To add a tag to a *Specialization* (that only has the default *human* tag costs the following:
 - **Superhuman:** 3 XP
 - **Simple & Weak:** 2 XP
 - **Complex & Powerful:** 2 XP
- To gain a +1 *Experience* costs 1 XP and then increasing it (to a maximum of +2) by 1 costs the score after the increase; so increasing a +1 experience to a +2 experience costs 2 XP.
- To gain an *Ability*.
- To upgrade a *Combat Style* or gain a new one as described in Section 3.5.
- To add additional features to their initial item or to construct additional items as described in Section 5.
- To increase their *Wealth* from Limited to Modest for 2 XP, from Modest to Comfortable for 6 XP, from Comfortable to Luxurious to 10 XP, or Luxurious to Aristocratic for 25 XP. A creature can also decrease their Wealth from Limited to None to gain 2 XP.

Throughout their journeys, characters will also earn XP that they can use to improve their characters. These may be spent in the same ways as above, but can also be spent to:

- Increase a basic statistic to +3; cost is as described above.
- Increase a character's Total *Life* beyond 40; the cost of each increase is one additional XP for each 10 points, so each point up to 50 costs 3 XP, up to 60 costs 4 XP, and so on.
- Increase a character's *Recovery* beyond 20; the cost of each increase is two additional XP for each 5 points, so each point up to 25 costs 6 XP, up to 30 costs 8 XP, and so on.
- Increase a character's *Block* up to 5; cost is as described above.
- Increase a *Specialization* bonus up to +4; cost is as described above.
- Increase an *Experience* bonus up to +3; cost is as described above.
- Gain an *Advanced Character Option* as described in Section 6.

4 Combat

Combat is broken up into rounds during which each participant has the chance to act. During each round, the GM and Players alternate taking turns to have one creature act, until all participants have acted; if there are more participants on one side or the other the remaining creatures generally act at the end, though one side may pass to allow the other to act an additional time. Either side may also spend *Advantage* once each turn to have two creatures go instead of just one. No creature can act more than once per round, except as allowed by an *Ability* or other rule.

On a creature's turn, they can move to any point the GM deems they could reasonably reach in a few moments without needing to make a roll and take **Actions** as described in Section 4.1.

4.1 Actions

There are three kinds of actions that characters can take during combat: **Main Actions**, **Quick Actions**, and **Defend Actions**. Main Actions and Quick Actions are taken on a character's turn in combat while Defend Actions can be taken when they are attacked. Each turn, every character gains a certain number of Main and Defend Actions they can use that round (generally one of each) and any unused actions at the end of round are wasted. Characters can use any number of Quick Actions per turn, though, with the GM's permission.

Main Actions Main Actions represent significant things that a character can do on their turn. This includes making an attack, taking more movement or movement that would require a roll (like moving over very rough terrain), *Helping* another character, interacting with a complex object, or other similar actions that the GM may permit.

Additionally, instead of taking a main action, a character can spend a Main Action in the following (or as allowed by another rule):

- When making an attack, a character can spend any number of additional Main Actions and to defend against the attack the target must use the same number of Defend Actions.
- When making an attack, a character can spend an additional Main Action to target a group of opponents that are clumped together within melee range (at the attacker's size) of each other.
- When performing triage, a character can spend an additional Main Action to target a group of creatures that are clumped together within melee range of each other.
- To take a Defend Action.
- To gain 2 Advantage.

For uses of a main action to boost an attack, the character must declare that use before any rolls for resolving the attack.

Quick Actions Quick Actions represent simple tasks like drinking a potion or drawing a weapon that a character can perform on their turn easily. A character can take any reasonable number of Quick Actions on their turn, as determined by the GM.

Defend Actions Defend Actions represent a character's ability to defend themselves from an attack. Using a Defend Action impacts the chances of the attack succeed and allows them, if they successfully avoid the attack, to hit back. Using a Defend Action also allows the character to activate a Defensive Combat Style which can provide additional bonuses like to the roll or other statistics.

4.2 Attacks

The mechanics of an attack depends on whether a Player Character (PC) is attacking a Non-Player Character (NPC) or vice-versa². The process of resolving an attack in each of these circumstances are described below.

PC Attacking NPC

1. The PC spends a Main Action and identifies the NPC (or NPCs) they are targeting, the weapon and the supported Offensive Combat Style they are using, and whether they are using any special features (such as expending additional Main Actions).
2. The GM determines, for each NPC being targeted, whether they will expend a Defend Action and if so the Defensive Combat Style they are using. The NPC will have a different difficulty to hit based on whether or not they use a Defend Action (generally the difficulty to hit is -1 if the NPC did not use a Defend Action).
3. The PC then makes a single roll against the difficulty to hit the NPCs, and the attack is resolved for each NPC based on the Outcome:

²These mechanics do not provide a mechanism for Player vs Player combat. If PvP arises, first the group should discuss if everyone is okay with it and if so what the goal or outcome of the combat will be. Then, these rules can be applied but using Opposed Rolls between the attacking and defending characters.

- **Very Bad:** The GM gains an Advantage. If the NPC took a Defend Action, and have an attack that could target the PC, they may deal damage to the PC and otherwise the GM gains another Advantage.
- **Bad:** If the NPC took a Defend Action, and have an attack that could target the PC, they may deal damage to the PC and otherwise the GM gains an Advantage.
- **Mixed:** The PC deals damage to the NPC. If the NPC took a Defend Action, and have an attack that could target the PC, they may deal damage to the PC and otherwise the GM gains an Advantage.
- **Good:** The PC deals damage to the NPC.
- **Very Good:** The PC gains an Advantage and deals damage to the NPC.

Once the PC rolls and determines the outcome, they can choose to spend additional Advantage to gain additional damage dice; if multiple NPCs were targeted by the attack the PC must spend an Advantage for an additional damage die for *each* NPC they wish to do the additional damage to.

When a PC deals damage to an NPC, the damage is determined by their Offensive Combat Style and their Weapon. The damage that an NPC does to a PC on a Mixed or worse result is determined by the NPC's statistics, and is generally less than they would deal on an attack against a PC. A PC can also spend Advantage (including the Advantage they receive on a Very Good result) to add additional damage dice, as described in Section 2.

NPC Attacking PC

1. The NPC spends a Main Action and identifies the PC (or PCs) they are targeting, the attack they are using (and any of its special features), and whether they are using any special features (such as expending additional Main Actions).
2. Each PC being targeted determines whether they will expend a Defend Action and if so the Defensive Combat Style they are using.
 - (a) If a PC does not use a Defend Action, the NPC automatically hits (unless the PC has the Armored Defensive Combat Style)³ and the NPC deals damage to them.
 - (b) If a PC does use a Defend Action they determine the Defensive Combat Style they are using and any associated weapon they are using. A PC may also have multiple Defensive Combat Styles that could be helpful, they may spend an Advantage to receive the benefits (other than benefits to the roll) of an additional Defensive Combat Style. The PC then gets to roll to avoid the hit using the Basic Statistic of their selected Defensive Combat Style and any bonuses it or their weapon grant, the difficulty of this roll is determined by the NPC's statistics. The attack is resolved based on the Outcome:
 - **Very Bad:** The GM gains an Advantage and the NPC deals damage to the PC.
 - **Bad:** The NPC deals damage to the PC.
 - **Mixed:** The NPC deals damage to the PC. If the PC took a Defend Action, and have an attack that could target the NPC, they may deal damage to the NPC or gain an Advantage.
 - **Good:** If the PC took a Defend Action, and have an attack that could target the NPC, they may deal damage to the NPC or gain an Advantage.
 - **Very Good:** If the PC took a Defend Action, they gain an Advantage and, if they have an attack that could target the NPC, they may deal damage to the NPC or gain an additional Advantage.

When an NPC deals damage to a PC, the amount of the damage is determined by their statistics. The damage a PC does to an NPC on a Mixed or better result is determined by their Weapon and the Basic Statistic of the Defensive Combat Style they used; it does not include any dice granted by their Offensive Combat Style. The GM can also spend Advantage to add additional damage dice but cannot spend more Advantage for additional damage on a single roll than the current round number (where the first round of combat is round 1).

Taking Damage Once an attack has been resolved, if the attacker deals damage to the target, the target first subtracts their *Block* from the damage rolled by the attacker and then any remaining damage is subtracted from its *Life*.

³This is an asymmetry to the system, PCs always have to roll to hit while NPCs do not. If a group does not like this rule you can instead simply use a higher Difficulty to avoid the hit if the PC does not use a Defend Action. This asymmetric rule is intentional and intended to reflect the danger and chaos of the world and to express that it is not necessarily fair to the PCs.

4.3 Healing

To recover *Life* lost during combat or otherwise during their adventures, creatures will need to **Heal**. When a creature successfully heals, it regains a number of *Life* equal to its *Recovery*. The easiest and simplest way to heal, is to get a night's rest; if a creature rests for 8 hours, with at least 6 hours of sleep and no strenuous activity over the period of time, they heal. Creatures can attempt to heal, or attempt to help another creature heal, in less time with a roll, with the difficulty depending on the time taken to heal. The *Difficulty* is generally set based on the time taken to rest: if they spend 4 hours the roll is *Very Easy*, 1 hour is *Easy*, 30 minutes is *Medium*, 10 minutes is *Hard*, and 1 minute is *Very Hard*. The GM may adjust these difficulties based on the situation, for instance a hospital might decrease the difficulty while a busy or dangerous environment may increase it. The time it takes to heal accounts both for time to tend wounds, relax, and so on, it also includes the time to find the necessary supplies; the GM may allow a shorter rest time without increasing the difficulty if sufficient supplies are available. Based on the situation, the GM may allow healing to be attempted as an *Action* in combat, though such a roll is likely to be *Very Hard* and *Decreased*. On a healing roll, the target of the healing regains *Life* equal to their *Recovery* if the roll is *Good* or *Very Good*, on a *Mixed* result they heal half of their *Recovery*. On a *Bad* or *Very Bad* result, the target does not heal but on a *Bad* result the GM should not impose a negative outcome, reserving that for a *Very Bad* result.

A creature can only benefit from the effects of a night's rest or a successful roll for healing once per day each.

4.3.1 Triaging

Sometime quicker healing is needed, especially if someone needs to be healed in the midst of combat. To attempt healing in the midst of combat, the healer must spend an *Advantage* and requires a relevant *Specialization* that can be used to help heal. The difficulty of the healing is generally *Medium*; on a success the target gains number of *Life* equal to the healer's specialization bonus. On a success, the healer can also spend *Advantage* to heal an additional *Life* per *Advantage*.

Once a creature is successfully healed in this manner attempts to heal them in this way again require spending an additional *Advantage*. If the *Specialization* used has the Simple & Weak tag, then the ability to use it for Triaging must be specifically defined as part of the ability.

4.4 Defeat

When a creature is reduced to 0 *Life*, they are **Defeated**. Depending on the circumstances, the GM may declare that the creature falls unconscious or becomes incapacitated for a number of hours, at which point they will awake with 1 *Life*. If the creature is still in danger, for instance in combat, the creature must choose one of the following options:

- **Unconsciousness:** the creature falls unconscious and is stable for the moment. An unconscious creature will remain unconscious for several hours, if not attended to, and then awaken with 1 *Life*. If an unconscious creature is hit by an attack, it becomes *Unstable*.
- **Unstable:** the creature remains alive but barely, with its fate hanging in the balance. The creature remains conscious and can act. At the end of each of its turns and each time an unstable creature takes damage, it must roll using its *Willpower Attribute* and must achieve a *Mixed* or better outcome; the *Difficulty* of this roll is *Very Easy* the first time and increases one step each time they roll. If an unstable creature fails this roll, it dies. An *Unstable* creature can be stabilized into *Unconsciousness* by a successful *Medium Difficulty* roll.

4.4.1 Optional Rule: Blaze of Glory

A group may chose to play with the following third option for when a player character is defeated:

- **Blaze of Glory:** the creature dies, but gets to take a final Action whose result is *Very Good*. This action may not be used to Heal itself.

4.4.2 Optional Rule: Resurrection

For groups that want it, death does not need to be the end of a character's journey, because there's magic in this world. A group should discuss whether they want to include resurrection in their game before beginning a campaign and exactly how it should work, but the following rules are provided as a suggestion.

Each character gains three boxes, that are initially unmarked, and marking these boxes represents the character's connection to the world slipping away. When a character dies, their party can attempt to resurrect them as an act of Big Magic, the magic should be made difficult not impossible, a Magnitude double the number of other party members is likely reasonable but the group should agree from the beginning. For each roll to perform the Big Magic that is a result of *Bad* or *Very Bad*, the dead character marks one of the boxes. If the character marks their third box they are permanently dead and cannot be restored to life as they have lost their connection to the world. If a character is successfully resurrected, they regain 1 *Life*. The process of dying and being resurrected has an impact on a character; they take a permanent -1 penalty to one of their experiences and gain a $+1$ bonus (or new $+1$ experience). They take an additional -1 penalty and $+1$ bonus for each box that was checked during their resurrection. A group and GM may choose to allow a player to spend 3 XP to unmark a marked box, in which case the character also loses the associated -1 penalty, thoughts keeps the $+1$ bonus they received.

If using the optional Blaze of Glory option described above, it is recommended that that option also marks all of the boxes immediately, heroic sacrifice is a lot less heroic and meaningful when they can be brought back.

If a character marks their last box during an attempt to resurrect them, if the player is interested and with the agreement of the GM and the group, the player may create a new character that possesses the body of their former character, as the failed resurrection actually brought some other being into the body. The new character should be created and leveled as normal, the player can choose whether or not to unmark the boxes and for each box left marked they retain a total of $+2$ experiences from the dead creature, representing how their new character still has some memory of the body's former occupant.

5 Items

Beyond a character's own abilities, they are also generally equipped with certain equipment that aids in their adventures. Much of the equipment is not noteworthy and can generally be assumed, but the key pieces of equipment are **Items** and given their own statistics. These statistics define bonuses and other features that the *Item* may grant to the character using it. *Items* fall into one of two categories: **Weapons** and **Relics**. Weapons, including defensive items like shields and armor, are associated with a particular Combat Style the character has and grant bonuses to combat abilities. Relics are any non-Weapon items and they grant the user an additional *Experience* that reflects the nature or possibly history of the Relic. Both Weapons and Relics can also grant other benefits, including bonuses to other *Attributes* or *Specializations*, additional *Experiences*, or even new *Abilities*.

5.1 Creating an Item

At character creation a character receives one Item for free, but otherwise creating an Item costs 1 XP which reflects the costs of time, money, and resources that procuring or creating the Item takes. For this cost, the item that is created is a *Basic Item*, the properties of which depend on whether it is a *Weapon* or *Relic*. When the item is created you can also spend XP to add additional features or improve on the Items basic features.

5.1.1 Creating a Basic Weapon

To create a basic weapon, choose one of the character's Combat Styles to associate it with. If the chosen Combat Style is Offensive, the item grants a $+1$ bonus to attack. If the chosen Combat Style is Defensive, the item grants a $+1$ bonus to defend.

5.1.2 Creating a Basic Relic

To create a basic relic, define the *Experience* that the Relic grants a $+1$ bonus for. At the beginning of each session, the Relic gains an *Advantage* (if it does not have one already) that can be spent as usual.

5.1.3 Finishing an Item

Finally, additional features can be purchased for an Item using XP.

- A bonus to an *Attribute*, to *Block*, to attack/defend (only for weapons), or a new *Experience* (or to increase the bonus to a relic's *Experience*). The cost of this bonus is based on the *total bonus* the item offers (this is the total bonus for attacking, defending, to *Attributes*, to *Block*, to *Experiences*, and to *Specializations*). For basic statistics and Block (which normally cost $3\times$ their new bonus), the cost is the total bonus plus

2× the total bonus to that stat or the total bonus to Block, respectively. For *Experiences* and bonuses to attack/defend the cost is just the new total bonus, and this is also the cost for adding a new +1 *Experience*. As an example, if we have a basic defensive weapon, which grants +1 to defend and 1 block, increasing the bonus to defend to +2 will cost 3 XP, and then adding a +1 bonus to *Strength* costs 6 XP (4 because the total bonus is now +4 and 2 more because the total bonus to Strength is +1 and the cost includes 2× that bonus). The maximum bonus to an *Attribute*, *Block*, *Experience*, or to attack or defend is +2 at character creation and +3 thereafter.

- A *Specialization* bonus can either offer just a bonus to one of the character's existing *Specializations* or can offer a new *Specialization*. The cost of a *Specialization* bonus is the same as described above (i.e., the total bonus the item offers after the new bonus) and if it provides a new *Specialization* then it also costs whatever tag it provides.
- A bonus to *Life* costs 2 XP per point up to a maximum bonus of +10.
- A bonus to *Recovery* costs 4 XP per point up to a maximum bonus of +5.
- Granting an *Ability* costs the cost of that *Ability*.

For weapons, the following options can also be added

- An additional Combat Style that the weapon can be used with costs 3 XP.
- The weapon can add additional damage to attacks using it, with the number of XP depending on the damage die added: 5 XP for a d4, 15 XP for a d6, 30 XP for a d8, 50 XP for a d10, and 75 XP for a d12 (an existing die can be increased to the next higher die size for the difference in their XP costs).

5.2 Other Item Rules

There are a few other Item rules, especially for governing how they interact. First, if a character has two Items which grant a bonus to the same thing (the same *Attribute* or *Specialization*) these bonuses do not stack, instead only the higher bonus applies. Similarly, if a character has multiple different weapons, the attack bonus only applies when using that specific weapon. For defensive weapons, similarly only the highest bonus to defend applies.

Additionally, if a character has more than 2 items in use (a character can hold onto other item but if they are not in use they would require several hours to be able to use them) they must hold onto 1 XP for each item past 2 they have.

Finally, sometimes a character outgrows a particular item, either they find something better or they have changed enough that the item no longer makes sense for them. In such case they can sell the item to regain all XP that they had invested in creating the item (make sure to track this for all Items); because this represents, in game, finding a buyer or perhaps melting down a weapon to forge it into something else. The GM may not allow an Item to be sold in a circumstance where it does not fit the narrative.

6 Advanced Character Options

This section describes Advanced Character Options, these are features and abilities that a character can gain access to as they advance. Some of these options include narrative components that the player must answer when taking the option and may require GM approval as well. This section is divided into several kinds of advanced options: Combat Styles, Attack Options, and Actions.

6.1 Offensive Combat Styles

Assassin You can only use this style to make an attack against a creature that is not aware of your presence. When you do, you automatically succeed at the attack. The range of attacks with this style is *in point-blank range*. Attacks with this style deal 1d8 damage.

Cost: 5 XP

Upgrades:

- The damage die can be changed to a d10 for 5 XP.

- The range can be changed to *within a short distance* for 3 XP.
- When you use this style you can gain an Advantage that must be used to deal an additional die of damage for 4 XP.

6.2 Defensive Combat Styles

Blink When you use this style, you can teleport a short distance to avoid an attack. If the outcome on the roll to avoid a hit is Mixed, you avoid the damage entirely, if it is Bad you take half damage, and if it is Very Bad you still take full damage.

Requires GM Approval

Cost: 8 XP

When you take this Defensive Combat Style, answer the following questions:

- What is the place you travel through when you teleport?
- How do you avoid the madness that place could cause?

Upgrades:

- Increase the distance you can teleport to a “long distance” for 5 XP.

Undying Fortitude When you use this style, if you take damage from a hit and the outcome of the roll was not Very Bad, your Life cannot be reduced below 1.

Requires GM Approval

Cost: 10 XP

When you take this Defensive Combat Style, describe the source of your undying strength.

6.3 Attack Options

Wide Barrage When making an attack, you can spend an additional Main Action to target a group of opponents that are near each other.

Cost: 10 XP

When you take this Attack Option, describe what your attack looks like.

Upgrades:

- Increase the distance the targeted opponents can be from each other to “in the same vicinity” for 10 XP.

Critical Attack When making an attack, you can spend an additional Main Action to double the damage you deal to the target.

Cost: 10 XP

When you take this Attack Option, describe how you empower an attack.

6.4 Alternative Main Actions

Dedicated Healer When taking a Main Action to perform triage, you can spend a Defend Action to eliminate any Advantage cost required for that roll.

Cost: 8 XP

Upgrades:

- When you use this feature, you can also increase the roll to triage for 5 XP.

Transformation You can spend a Main Action and a Defend Action to transform your physical form; you can also transform once per session outside of combat. Pick one of the following options for the remainder of the scene or until you end the transformation:

- Your current and maximum Life increase by 10 for the duration (when you revert, if you still have any of these additional Life you lose them). While transformed, you cannot use any benefit of your Offensive Combat Styles other than range and the Basic Statistic's bonus to attack rolls, this means your damage is 0 plus any damage granted by any weapon you still wield.
- Whenever you deal damage while transformed add an additional damage die. While transformed, you cannot use any benefit of your Defensive Combat Styles other than the Basic Statistic's bonus to rolls to avoid being hit.
- Your speed is doubled and you gain a +2 bonus to all Finesse rolls for the duration. While transformed, you suffer a -1 penalty to your Strength and Willpower.
- You gain a +2 bonus to all Instinct rolls for the duration. Additionally, you gain any single Specialization, with a bonus of +1 and the Superhuman tag, with the "Perceive" verb; if you already have such a Specialization you can gain an additional +1 bonus to that Specialization instead. While transformed, you suffer a -1 penalty to your Presence and Knowledge.

Additionally, while transformed you cannot utilize any of your Specializations, other than any which receive a bonus by the transformation.

Requires GM Approval

Cost: 10 XP

When you take this option, answer the following questions:

- What do you look like when transformed?
- What instinct do you have to resist while transformed?

Upgrades:

- The number of times you can transform out of combat can be increased to 5 for 5 XP or the limit can be removed entirely for 10 XP.
- While transformed you can use any of your Specializations for 4 XP.
- While transformed you can gain a Swim, Climb, or Fly (choose when you take this upgrade) speed equal to your Walk speed for 2 XP.
- You can gain the ability to activate two options for 5 XP, the ability to activate three options for 12 XP, and the ability to activate all four options for 20 XP.

The four options additionally have the following upgrades for their positive benefits, each of which costs 5 XP:

- Your current and maximum Life increase by 20 instead of 10.
- Whenever you deal damage add two additional damage dice, instead of one.
- Gain a +4, instead of +2, bonus to all Finesse rolls.
- Gain a +4, instead of +2, bonus to all Instinct rolls.

Additionally, the negative effects for a single option can be eliminated for 8 XP, or the effects for a single option can be reduced as described below for 4 XP:

- You can benefit from the damage dice of your Offensive Combat Styles, though still do not benefit from any other bonuses or features they provide.
- While you are transformed you gain a +1 bonus to rolls to avoid being hit (though you still cannot use any benefits of your Defensive Combat Styles).
- When you transform you suffer a -1 penalty to only one of Strength and Willpower, you choose when you transform.
- When you transform you suffer a -1 penalty to only one of Presence and Knowledge, you choose when you transform.

6.5 Actions

Additional Defend Actions You can increase the number of Defend Actions you receive each round for a number of XP equal to $8\times$ the number of Main Actions you will receive after the increase (so the first additional Main Action costs 16 XP, the next 24 XP).

Additional Main Actions You can increase the number of Main Actions you receive each round for a number of XP equal to $10\times$ the number of Main Actions you will receive after the increase (so the first additional Main Action costs 20 XP, the next 30 XP).

Action Carryover Instead of losing any Main or Defend Actions you have remaining at the end of a round of combat, you can keep 1 Main or Defend Action into the next round.

Cost: 5 XP

Upgrades:

- Increase the number of actions you can carry over to the next round for XP equal to $5\times$ the new number of actions you can carry over.

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A Inspirations and Mechanics Borrowed From

- Ars Magica
- Daggerheart
- Fudge
- Prismatic Wasteland
- Tavern Tales

B Development Notes

To Do List

- Companion options
- Experience Points as money/resources